Screen lock and clean desk policy

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Summary

Acme Global's screen-lock and clean-desk policy requires that all workstations be locked whenever the user steps away and that desks remain free of sensitive information. This article explains the policy requirements, how to configure automatic lock settings on Windows and macOS devices, manual lock best practices, verification steps, and the service-desk process for handling non-compliance.

Symptoms

- Screen stays unlocked when the user walks away from the desk
- Confidential data visible on an unattended monitor
- Audit logs show no lock or sign-in events for extended periods
- Spot-check audits reveal papers, notes, or devices containing sensitive information left on the desk

Common causes

- Automatic lock timeout is disabled or set to a value longer than the allowed 5 minutes
- Users rely on memory to lock the screen and forget to press the lock shortcut
- Intune or Group Policy settings that enforce lock timing have not been applied to the device
- Physical workspace clutter prevents the user from quickly securing the desk before leaving

Policy Overview

Acme Global expects every employee to protect confidential information by locking their screen whenever they step away from the workstation, even for a brief moment. The clean-desk rule complements this by requiring that desks be cleared of papers, notes, removable media, and any device that could expose sensitive data when unattended. These controls reduce the risk of shoulder surfing, unauthorized access, and data leakage.

The policy aligns with industry standards (ISO 27001, NIST CSF) and is enforced through a combination of technical controls (automatic lock via Intune/Group Policy) and procedural checks (periodic desk audits performed by Security Operations and Facilities). Violations are logged and may result in remedial training or, for repeat offenses, escalation to management.

Self-Help: Enable Automatic Screen Lock

If your device does not lock automatically after a short period of inactivity, you can verify and adjust the setting yourself. The steps below apply to both Windows 11 and macOS devices managed by Intune. After making changes, lock the device manually once to confirm the new timeout takes effect.

Note: If you receive a message that settings are managed by your organization and cannot be changed, contact the IT Service Desk - the required policy may be pending deployment.

1. Windows 11:
1. Press Win?+?I to open Settings.
2. Choose Personalization -> Lock screen.
3. Scroll down and click Screen timeout settings.
4. Under "Screen", set "On battery power, turn off after" and "When plugged in, turn off after" to 5 minutes or less.
5. Close Settings; the change is saved immediately.

macOS Ventura/Sonoma:
1. Click the Apple menu ? -> System Settings.
2. Select Lock Screen from the sidebar.
3. Set "Turn display off after" to 5 minutes for both "Battery" and "Power Adapter".

4. Close System Settings to apply.

Manual Lock Best Practices

Even with an automatic timeout, it is good practice to lock the screen immediately when you leave your desk. This eliminates any window of exposure and reinforces the habit of a clean desk.

Use the platform-specific shortcut:
- Windows: Win?+?L
- macOS: Control?+?Command?+?Q

If you are using a external monitor, ensure the shortcut locks the entire session, not just the primary display. After locking, verify that the login screen appears before walking away.

Verification: Confirming Lock Settings

To be certain that your device complies with the policy, perform a quick check after configuring the timeout or before leaving your desk for an extended period.

1. Lock the device manually using the appropriate shortcut.
2. Wait the configured timeout period (e.g., 5 minutes) without touching the mouse or keyboard.
3. Observe that the screen returns to the lock/login prompt automatically.
4. On Windows, you can also run `powercfg /query` in a Command Prompt to see the current video timeout values.
5. On macOS, run `pmset -g | grep displaysleep` in Terminal to verify the setting.

If the screen does not lock as expected, repeat the self-help steps or contact the Service Desk for assistance.

Service Desk Procedure

When a user reports a screen-lock issue or a clean-desk violation is identified during an audit, the Service Desk follows this workflow:

1. **Ticket creation** - Log the incident in the ITSM tool with category "Security - Screen Lock/Clean Desk". Include the user's name, employee ID, device hostname, and a description of the observed symptom.
2. **Initial triage** - Verify whether the device is managed by Intune and check the latest compliance report for the "Device lock timeout" setting. If the setting shows as non-compliant, proceed to remediation.
3. **Remote remediation** - For Windows devices, push a fresh Intune policy that sets the screen timeout to 5 minutes. For macOS, ensure the "Lock Screen" profile is deployed and re-sync the device.
4. **User communication** - Notify the user of the change, provide the self-help shortcut reminder, and ask them to confirm the lock works after the policy applies.
5. **Closure and documentation** - Close the ticket once the device reports compliant and the user confirms. Attach screenshots of the Intune compliance status and any user acknowledgment.

If the device remains non-compliant after two policy pushes, escalate to the Identity & Access Management team for a deeper look at possible conflicting configurations.

Escalation and Reporting

If the Service Desk cannot resolve the issue within the agreed SLA (P3 Moderate - 24?hours) or if the user repeatedly disables lock settings, the matter must be escalated.

- **Escalation trigger**: No compliance after two remote policy pushes, or evidence of intentional bypass (e.g., registry edits, plist modifications).
- **Target group**: Security Operations (owning group) - they will conduct a forensic review of the device, check for malware or unauthorized scripts, and determine whether a policy exception is warranted.
- **Information to include**: Device serial number, Intune device ID, recent compliance logs, screenshots of the non-compliant setting, and a summary of user interactions (ticket history, any reported attempts to disable lock).

Security Operations will decide on further actions, which may include issuing a Temporary Access Pass for re-enrollment, initiating a security awareness refresher, or, in cases of deliberate policy violation, invoking the disciplinary process outlined in the Employee Handbook.

When to escalate

Escalate to Security Operations when the screen-lock setting remains non-compliant after two Intune policy remediation attempts or when there is evidence of intentional bypass. Include the device hostname, Intune device ID, latest compliance report, screenshots of the offending setting, and a concise ticket summary. Security Operations will perform a forensic review, determine if an exception is justified, and coordinate any required user retraining or disciplinary steps.

Keywords: screen lock, clean desk, auto lock, timeout, Win+L, Control+Command+Q, Intune compliance, device lock, workstation security, desk audit, policy violation, security operations, service desk